Skimbleshanks: The Railway Cat

1. There's a whisper down the line at 11.39
2. When the Night Mail's ready to depart,
3. Saying "Skimble where is Skimble has he gone to hunt the thimble?
4. We must find him or the train can't start."
5. All the guards and all the porters and the stationmaster's daughters
6. They are searching high and low,
7. Saying "Skimble where is Skimble for unless he's very nimble
8. Then the Night Mail just can't go."
9. At 11.42 then the signal's nearly due
10. And the passengers are frantic to a man—
11. Then Skimble will appear and he'll saunter to the rear:
12. He's been busy in the luggage van!
13. He gives one flash of his glass-green eyes
14. And the signal goes "All Clear!"
15. And we're off at last for the northern part
16. Of the Northern Hemisphere!
17. You may say that by and large it is Skimble who's in charge
18. Of the Sleeping Car Express.
19. From the driver and the guards to the bagmen playing cards
20. He will supervise them all, more or less.
21. Down the corridor he paces and examines all the faces
22. Of the travellers in the First and the Third;
23. He establishes control by a regular patrol
24. And he'd know at once if anything occurred.

25.He will watch you without winking and he sees what you are thinking

26.And it's certain that he doesn't approve

27.Of hilarity and riot, so the folk are very quiet

28.When Skimble is about and on the move.

29.You can play no pranks with Skimbleshanks!

30.He's a Cat that cannot be ignored;

31. So nothing goes wrong on the Northern Mail

32.When Skimbleshanks is aboard.

33.Oh, it's very pleasant when you have found your little den

34.With your name written up on the door.

35.And the berth is very neat with a newly folded sheet

36.And there's not a speck of dust on the floor.

37.There is every sort of light—you can make it dark or bright;

38.There's a handle that you turn to make a breeze.

39.There's a funny little basin you're supposed to wash your face in

40.And a crank to shut the window if you sneeze.

41. Then the guard looks in politely and will ask you very brightly

42."Do you like your morning tea weak or strong?"

43.But Skimble's just behind him and was ready to remind him,

44.For Skimble won't let anything go wrong.

45.And when you creep into your cosy berth

46.And pull up the counterpane,

47.You ought to reflect that it's very nice

48.To know that you won't be bothered by mice—

49.You can leave all that to the Railway Cat,

50.The Cat of the Railway Train!

51. In the watches of the night he is always fresh and bright;

52. Every now and then he has a cup of tea

53. With perhaps a drop of Scotch while he's keeping on the watch,

54. Only stopping here and there to catch a flea.

55. You were fast asleep at Crewe and so you never knew

56. That he was walking up and down the station;

57. You were sleeping all the while he was busy at Carlisle,

58. Where he greets the stationmaster with elation.

59. But you saw him at Dumfries, where he speaks to the police

60. If there's anything they ought to know about:

61. When you get to Gallowgate there you do not have to wait—

62. For Skimbleshanks will help you to get out!

63. He gives you a wave of his long brown tail

64. Which says: "I'll see you again!

65. You'll meet without fail on the Midnight Mail

Line 1

"There's a whisper down the line at 11.39"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Whisper:** Talking very quietly so others can't hear. 🤫
    - **Down the line:** Along the railway tracks or through the people working at the station.
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"There's a whisper":** People are sharing a secret or news quietly.
    - **"down the line":** The news is traveling from one worker to the next.
    - **"at 11.39":** The specific time, one minute before the train is supposed to leave.
- **Literal Meaning:** At 11:39 PM, a quiet rumor is spreading among the railway staff.

Line 2

"When the Night Mail's ready to depart,"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Night Mail:** A famous British train that traveled at night to deliver letters (mail). ✉️
    - **Depart:** To leave a place; to start a journey. 🛫
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"When the Night Mail's":** Referring to the specific train.
    - **"ready to depart":** The train is all packed and the engine is ready to go.
- **Literal Meaning:** The mail train is completely ready to leave the station.

Line 3

"Saying 'Skimble where is Skimble has he gone to hunt the thimble?'"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Hunt the thimble:** An old children's game where you have to find a hidden "thimble" (a small metal cap for sewing). 🪡
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Saying 'Skimble where is Skimble'":** The question everyone is asking.
    - **"has he gone to hunt the thimble?":** A joking way of asking if he is playing hide-and-seek.
- **Literal Meaning:** People are looking for Skimble and joking that maybe he is playing a game.

Line 4

"We must find him or the train can't start."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Start:** To begin moving (for a train).
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"We must find him":** It is a high priority to locate him.
    - **"or the train can't start":** The train is stuck without him. 🚫

Line 5

"All the guards and all the porters and the stationmaster's daughters"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Guards:** People who look after the safety of the train. 👮
    - **Porters:** People who carry bags and luggage for passengers. 🧳
    - **Stationmaster:** The "boss" or manager of the whole railway station.
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"All the guards and all the porters":** Every single worker.

    - **"and the stationmaster's daughters":** Even the boss's family members.
- **Literal Meaning:** Everyone at the station is helping to look for the cat.

Line 6

"They are searching high and low,"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Searching:** Looking for something.
    - **High and low:** An idiom meaning "everywhere" (up in high places and down on the ground). 🌍
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"They are searching":** They are putting in effort to find him.
    - **"high and low":** They are checking every corner.
- **Literal Meaning:** People are looking everywhere possible for Skimbleshanks.

Line 7

"Saying 'Skimble where is Skimble for unless he's very nimble"

Tough Words:

- **For:** In this poem, "for" means **"because."** 💡
- **Unless:** This means **"if... not."** (For example: "Unless you study, you won't pass" means "If you do *not* study, you won't pass.") 🚫
- **Nimble:** To be very **quick, light, and fast** in the way you move. Think of a cat jumping over a fence or a gymnast doing a flip. 🤸‍♂️

Phrase Breakdown:

- **"Saying 'Skimble where is Skimble'":** This describes the noise at the station. Everyone (the guards, the porters) is repeating the same worried question over and over because they are panicking. 🗣️❓
- **"for unless he's very nimble":** This means: **"Because if he is NOT super fast..."** 🕒

 Literal Meaning (Detailed):

- Imagine the scene: The clock is ticking toward the departure time. The train is standing still, and the steam is rising. Everyone is looking for the cat. The workers are saying to each other, "We have a huge problem! The train is ready to leave, but Skimble is still missing. **If he is not incredibly fast and quick on his feet (nimble)** to run here and jump onto the train in the next few seconds, we are going to be late!" They are basically saying that the only way the train can leave on time is if Skimble uses his amazing "cat-speed" to get back to his post right now. If he is slow, the whole railway system fails. 🐱⚡🚂

Line 8

"Then the Night Mail just can't go."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Go:** To leave the station. 🛑
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Then the Night Mail":** The train.
    - **"just can't go":** It is impossible for it to leave.
- **Literal Meaning:** The journey cannot start without him.

Line 9

"At 11.42 then the signal's nearly due"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Signal:** The railway light (green means go, red means stop). 🚦
    - **Due:** Expected at a certain time; almost time for it to happen.
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"At 11.42":** Time is passing quickly!
    - **"then the signal's nearly due":** The green light is about to appear.
- **Literal Meaning:** It is now 11:42 PM, and the light is about to change for the train to leave

ine 10

"And the passengers are frantic to a man—"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Passengers:** The people traveling on the train. 👥
    - **Frantic:** Extremely worried, panicked, or upset. 😨
    - **To a man:** An idiom meaning "every single person" (without exception).
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"And the passengers are frantic":** The travelers are panicking.
    - **"to a man":** Every single passenger feels this way.
- **Literal Meaning:** Every person on the train is very stressed and worried that they will be late.

Line 11

"Then Skimble will appear and he'll saunter to the rear:"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Appear:** To suddenly show up or become visible. ✨
    - **Saunter:** To walk in a slow, relaxed, and confident way (like you don't have a care in the world). 😎
    - **Rear:** The back part of something (the back of the train).
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Then Skimble will appear":** He finally shows up.
    - **"and he'll saunter":** He walks very calmly.
    - **"to the rear":** Toward the back of the train.
- **Literal Meaning:** Just as everyone is panicking, Skimble walks out very slowly and calmly.

- **Deep Meaning:** This is a **Contrast**. The humans are "frantic," but the cat is "sauntering." This proves he is the boss. He is not worried because he knows he is in control.
- **The Saunter:** Once he shows his face (to prove he isn't missing), he doesn't stay to talk to the humans. He **"saunters"** (walks coolly) back to his favorite spot at the **rear** (the luggage van) to get back to work. 🐾

Line 12

"He's been busy in the luggage van!"

- **Tough Words:**
  - **Busy:** Working on something; having a lot to do.
  - **Luggage van:** The specific carriage or room on a train where bags and boxes are stored. 📦
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
  - **"He's been busy":** He was working hard.
  - **"in the luggage van":** In the storage area.
- **Literal Meaning:** He wasn't playing; he was actually doing his job in the luggage room

Line 13

"He gives one flash of his glass-green eyes"

- **Tough Words:**
  - **Flash:** A sudden, quick, and bright light (like a camera flash). 📸
  - **Glass-green:** A very bright, shiny green color, similar to a green glass marble or a traffic light. 🟢
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
  - **"He gives one flash":** He looks around quickly with a sharp, bright stare.
  - **"of his glass-green eyes":** Describing his glowing cat eyes that shine in the dark station.

- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Imagine the dark platform at night. Skimble has just appeared. He doesn't meow or make a noise; he simply looks at the station staff and the driver. In the dim light of the railway station, his eyes catch the light and "flash" a bright green color. This look is a message to everyone. It says, "I am here, I have checked everything, and I am ready." It is his way of giving the "thumbs up" to the humans so the journey can start. 🐈‍⬛✨

Line 14

"And the signal goes 'All Clear!'"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Signal:** The big light or wooden arm next to the tracks that tells the driver if it is safe to move (Green = Go, Red = Stop). 🚦
    - **All Clear:** A railway phrase that means "The tracks are empty and safe; you have permission to go now." ✅
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"And the signal goes":** The railway machine changes its status.
    - **"'All Clear!'":** The light turns green or the sign moves to show it's safe.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** As soon as Skimbleshanks gives that green "flash" with his eyes, the railway signal light immediately changes to green. It is as if the machinery of the entire British railway system was waiting for this specific cat to get on board. Now that he is there, the station workers pull the levers, the lights change, and the "All Clear" message is given to the driver in the engine. The path is now open for the train to leave the station. 🏞️✅
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows the **Connection between Nature and Machine**.

Line 15

"And we're off at last for the northern part"

- **Tough Words:**

    - **Off at last:** Finally starting the journey after a long and stressful delay. 🕛
    - **Northern part:** The direction the train is heading (toward the North of England and Scotland). 🗺️
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"And we're off at last":** The train finally begins to move.
    - **"for the northern part":** Traveling toward the northern regions.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The big steam engine finally huffs and puffs, and the wheels start to turn. After all the "whispering" and "frantic" panicking of the passengers, the train is finally leaving London. There is a feeling of relief! The "Night Mail" is now picking up speed, leaving the station behind, and beginning its long trip toward the cold, hilly lands of the North. The waiting is over, and the adventure has officially started. 🚂🕛

Line 16

"Of the Northern Hemisphere!"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Northern Hemisphere:** The top half of the planet Earth (everything north of the Equator). 🌍
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Of the Northern":** Describing the cold, top part of the world.
    - **"Hemisphere!":** Half of the globe.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The poet uses very big, dramatic language here. Instead of just saying "the train is going to Scotland," he says it is traveling across the **Northern Hemisphere**. This makes the train journey feel like a giant, world-wide mission. It makes the "Night Mail" sound like the most important train on the entire planet. It tells us that Skimble isn't just guarding a local train; he is guarding a journey that spans half the world! 🌎⭐
- **Deep Meaning:** This is called **Hyperbole** (Exaggeration).

Line 17

"You may say that by and large it is Skimble who's in charge"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **By and large:** Mostly or in general. ⚖️
    - **In charge:** The person who has the power to give orders; the leader. 👑
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"You may say that":** It is true to say.
    - **"by and large":** Generally speaking.
    - **"it is Skimble who's in charge":** Skimble is the real boss of the train.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** If you watch how the train operates, you will see that many humans are working, but it is actually the cat who is leading them. Even though he doesn't have a title like "Director," his influence is everywhere. Most people would agree that Skimble is the one making sure everything works correctly from start to finish. He is the unofficial leader of the whole operation. 🐾
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Hierarchy**

Line 18

"Of the Sleeping Car Express."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Sleeping Car:** A special train carriage with beds (berths) for people to sleep in at night. 🛌
    - **Express:** A very fast train that doesn't stop at small, unimportant stations. ⚡
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Of the Sleeping Car":** The part of the train where people rest.

    - **"Express":** A high-speed, high-quality train.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** This tells us exactly what kind of train Skimble manages. It isn't a slow, dirty train; it is the "Sleeping Car Express." This is a fancy, fast-moving train where people pay a lot of money to have a bed and sleep comfortably while they travel through the night. Skimble is responsible for this high-end, moving hotel. 🏨🚂

Line 19

"From the driver and the guards to the bagmen playing cards"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Driver:** The person who operates the engine. 👮
    - **Guards:** People responsible for the train's safety and the doors.
    - **Bagmen:** Workers who handle the heavy mail bags and luggage. 💼
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"From the driver and the guards":** From the highest workers.
    - **"to the bagmen playing cards":** To the lower-level workers who are relaxing.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Skimble's eyes are on everyone! He watches the driver at the very front of the train, the guards in the middle, and even the workers in the storage area who are passing time by playing card games. Whether a worker is doing something very important or just relaxing, Skimble is there to see it. No one is "too high" or "too low" for him to check on. 🃏👀
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Total Supervision**.

Line 20

"He will supervise them all, more or less."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Supervise:** To watch and direct people to make sure they are working correctly. 🧐

    - **More or less:** Mostly; almost entirely.
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"He will supervise":** He will act as the manager.
    - **"them all, more or less":** He watches every single person on the train.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Skimble's main job while the train is moving is to walk around and make sure every human is doing their duty. He ensures the driver stays awake, the guards stay alert, and the workers don't get too distracted by their games. He is like a quality-control inspector who never takes a break. He makes sure the "Night Mail" stays a perfect machine. 🏭🐈‍⬛
- **Deep Meaning:** This reinforces the idea of **Order**. Without Skimble's "supervision," the humans might become lazy or careless. He is the reason the train is efficient and reliable. ⚖️

Line 21

"Down the corridor he paces and examines all the faces"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Corridor:** The long, narrow hallway inside the train carriages. 🏞️
    - **Paces:** To walk back and forth with slow, steady steps. 🚶
    - **Examines:** To look at something or someone very closely and carefully. 🔍
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Down the corridor he paces":** He walks through the narrow hallway of the train.
    - **"and examines all the faces":** He looks closely at every single traveler.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** As the train speeds through the dark night, Skimble walks up and down the long hallways. He doesn't just walk for

fun; he stops to look at every passenger's face. He wants to know who is on his train. He is checking to see if anyone looks suspicious, sick, or unhappy. He is like a security guard performing a "face-check" on every person on board. 🐈‍⬛👤

- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Diligence** (Hard Work

Line 22

"Of the travellers in the First and the Third;"

- **Tough Words:**
  - **Travellers:** The passengers on the train. 👥
  - **First:** "First Class"—the expensive, rich section. 💎
  - **Third:** "Third Class"—the cheaper section for regular people. 🎟️
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
  - **"Of the travellers":** The people on the journey.
  - **"in the First and the Third":** In the rich section and the common section.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** In the old days, trains were strictly divided. The rich people sat in "First Class" and everyone else sat in "Third Class." But Skimble is a very fair cat! He doesn't care about how much money you have. He walks through the fancy carriages and the simple carriages equally. He checks the rich and the poor with the same level of care and attention. 🌍
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Equality**

Line 23

"He establishes control by a regular patrol"

- **Tough Words:**
  - **Establishes:** To set up or create a system. 🏗️
  - **Control:** Power or influence over others. 🎮

    - **Regular:** Happening at the same time or in the same way. ⏱️
    - **Patrol:** Walking around an area to guard it. 👮‍♂️
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"He establishes control":** He makes sure he is the boss.
    - **"by a regular patrol":** By walking around the train again and again at set times.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Skimble maintains order by being very consistent. He has a routine. Because the passengers and workers see him walking past their doors at the same time every night, they know he is watching. This "patrol" makes everyone feel safe, but it also makes them behave because they know the "Police Cat" is nearby. 🛡️🐾
- **Deep Meaning:** This is the definition of **Discipline**

Line 24

"And he'd know at once if anything occurred."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **At once:** Immediately; right away. ⚡
    - **Occurred:** Happened (usually something unexpected or a problem). ⚠️
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"And he'd know at once":** He would find out the very second it happened.
    - **"if anything occurred":** If any problem or event took place.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Skimble is so alert that nothing can happen on the train without him knowing. If a window is left open, if someone is whispering a secret, or if a light goes out, Skimble will find out immediately because he is always moving and always watching. He is the "eyes and ears" of the Night Mail. 🕵️‍♂️✨
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Vigilance** (Alertness).

Line 25

"He will watch you without winking and he sees what you are thinking"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Without winking:** Without even blinking his eyes; staring very steadily. 👁️
    - **Thinking:** The private thoughts inside your mind. 🧠
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"He will watch you without winking":** He gives you a very long, intense stare.
    - **"and he sees what you are thinking":** He can almost read your mind.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** When Skimble looks at you, it can be a bit scary! He has a way of staring at a passenger without even blinking his eyes. His stare is so deep and sharp that you feel like he knows all your secrets. If you were thinking about being noisy or breaking a rule, you feel like Skimble has already caught you just by looking at you. 😼👁️
- **Deep Meaning:** This is **Mysticism**.

Line 26

"And it's certain that he doesn't approve"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Certain:** 100% sure; there is no doubt. ✅
    - **Approve:** To think that something is good or right. 👍
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"And it's certain":** We are absolutely sure.
    - **"that he doesn't approve":** That he thinks it is wrong or bad.

- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** There is no question about it: Skimble is a very serious and strict cat. He has very high standards for how people should behave on his train. You can see it in his face—if you are doing something silly or messy, he is judging you. He believes a train should be a place of quiet and order. ❌😾
- **Deep Meaning:** Skimble represents **Moral Authority**. He is the "conscience" of the train. He reminds the humans to be their best selves.

Line 27

"Of hilarity and riot, so the folk are very quiet"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Hilarity:** Very loud laughing, joking, or being noisy. 😂
    - **Riot:** Wild, messy, or uncontrolled behavior (like a noisy party). 🎊
    - **Folk:** The people (passengers). 👥
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Of hilarity and riot":** Of loud noise and wild fun.
    - **"so the folk are very quiet":** Therefore, the people stay very silent.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Skimble hates it when people are being too loud, laughing uncontrollably, or making a mess (riot). Because the passengers are a little bit afraid of his serious stare, they choose to stay very quiet and well-behaved. He "shushes" the whole train without even making a sound! Everyone behaves properly because they don't want the cat to "disapprove" of them. 🤫🚂
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Influence**.

Line 28

"When Skimble is about and on the move."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **About:** Nearby; around the area.

    - **On the move:** Walking or traveling from one place to another. 🚶
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"When Skimble is about":** When he is in the area.
    - **"and on the move":** And when he is walking through the halls.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** As long as people see Skimble walking through the carriages, they stay on their best behavior. The moment they see him "on the move" (patrolling the halls), the noise stops and the order begins. His mere presence is enough to keep the entire Sleeping Car Express a peaceful place for everyone to rest. 🐈‍⬛✨
- **Deep Meaning:** This is the **Power of Presence**.

Line 29

"You can play no pranks with Skimbleshanks!"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Pranks:** Practical jokes or naughty tricks meant to fool someone. 🃏🚫
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"You can play no pranks":** You cannot trick him or play jokes on him.
    - **"with Skimbleshanks!":** Referring to the cat by his full name.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** If you were thinking about playing a joke on the cat or trying to hide from him, forget it! Skimble is too smart and too alert. You cannot trick him or make a fool of him. He is always one step ahead of any naughty passenger or worker who wants to cause trouble. He is the ultimate "No-Nonsense" cat. 😾❌
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Infallibility** (He cannot be fooled)

Line 30

"He's a Cat that cannot be ignored;"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Ignored:** To pretend you don't see someone or to pay no attention to them. 🙈
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"He's a Cat":** Identifying him.
    - **"that cannot be ignored":** That you MUST pay attention to.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** You might think "He's just a cat, I'll just walk past him," but you can't! Skimble has such a strong personality and such a powerful "vibe" that you have to notice him. Whether he is walking past your seat or staring at you from the corridor, his presence fills the room. Everyone on the train is aware of where he is at all times. 🌟🐾
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Charisma**.

Line 31

"So nothing goes wrong on the Northern Mail"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Northern Mail:** Another name for the "Night Mail" train heading north. 🚂📬
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"So nothing goes wrong":** Therefore, everything stays perfect.
    - **"on the Northern Mail":** On this specific train.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Because of all his hard work—his patrolling, his staring, his supervising, and his "All-Seeing" eyes—everything on the train happens exactly as it should. There are no delays, no accidents, and no messy passengers. The train is a perfect machine because the cat is there to make it so. ✅💯
- **Deep Meaning:** This is the **Result of Leadership**.

Line 32

"When Skimbleshanks is aboard."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Aboard:** On or in a ship, aircraft, or train. 🚂🏠
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"When Skimbleshanks":** The name of the hero.
    - **"is aboard":** Is present on the train.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** This is the final conclusion of the stanza. The "secret" to the train's perfect record is simply that Skimbleshanks is there. As long as he is on the train, the journey will be safe, quiet, and on time. He is the "Good Luck Charm" and the "Strong Manager" combined into one furry body. 🐈‍⬛🍀

- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Indispensability** (He is necessary).

We are moving into the **comfort zone** of the train! 🚂✨ In these lines (33-50), the poet describes how wonderful it feels to be a passenger on Skimble's train. It feels like a high-end hotel on wheels.

Line 33

"Oh, it's very pleasant when you have found your little den"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Pleasant:** Something that makes you feel happy, comfortable, and relaxed. 😊
    - **Den:** Usually a home for a wild animal (like a lion), but here it means a **small, cozy, and private room**. 🏠
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Oh, it's very pleasant":** It feels really good.

    - **"when you have found your little den":** When you finally get into your private cabin on the train.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Imagine traveling on a cold, dark night. You finally walk into your private room on the train. It isn't huge, but it is warm and quiet. The poet calls it a "den" because it feels safe and tucked away from the rest of the world. It is your own little "home" for the night. 🛌
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Security**. Even in a fast-moving machine, Skimble makes sure the passengers feel like they are in a safe "den." 🦁🛡️

Line 34

"With your name written up on the door."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Written up:** Displayed or put on a sign. 🏷️
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"With your name":** Your personal identity.
    - **"written up on the door":** Placed on the entrance of your cabin.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** On the fancy Night Mail, you aren't just a number. When you get to your room, there is a little card or sign on the door with your name on it. This makes the passenger feel very important and "at home." It shows that the train staff was expecting you. 🎟️👤
- **Deep Meaning:** This represents **Personal Care**. Skimble's leadership ensures that every passenger feels special and respected. It's about high-quality service. ✨

Line 35

"And the berth is very neat with a newly folded sheet"

- **Tough Words:**

    - **Berth:** A built-in bed on a train or a ship. 🛏️
    - **Neat:** Very clean, tidy, and organized. ✨
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"And the berth is very neat":** The bed is perfectly made.
    - **"with a newly folded sheet":** The bedsheets are fresh, clean, and pressed.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** You look at your bed and it looks perfect. The sheets are white, clean, and folded exactly right. There are no wrinkles or mess. It looks so inviting that you want to jump right in. Everything is in its place. 🧺🧤
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Precision**. Skimble doesn't just watch the engine; he watches the laundry! He ensures that "Order" exists even in the smallest details of a bedsheet. 📏

Line 36

"And there's not a speck of dust on the floor."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Speck:** A very, very tiny piece of something. 👌
    - **Dust:** Tiny bits of dirt. 🧹
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"And there's not a speck":** There isn't even a tiny bit.
    - **"of dust on the floor":** The floor is perfectly clean.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The room is incredibly clean. Usually, trains can be a bit dirty or dusty because of the coal and the tracks, but not this one. The floor is so clean you could probably eat off it! Skimble has clearly made sure the cleaners did a perfect job. ✨🧹
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Excellence**. Skimble's standards are "100%." He doesn't accept "mostly clean"; he only accepts "perfectly clean." 💎

Line 37

"There is every sort of light—you can make it dark or bright;"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Every sort:** All different kinds. 💡
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"There is every sort of light":** There are many different lamps and switches.
    - **"you can make it dark or bright":** You can control how much light you want.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** In your little room, you have total control. If you want to read a book, you can turn on a bright light. If you want to sleep, you can make it completely dark. If you want it "cozy," you can have a dim light. The train provides everything you need to be comfortable. 🕯️ 🔦
- **Deep Meaning:** This represents **Luxury and Control**. The passenger is the "king" of their room. Skimble makes sure the environment adapts to what the human wants. 👑

Line 38

"There's a handle that you turn to make a breeze."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Handle:** A part of a machine you hold and turn with your hand. ⚙️
    - **Breeze:** A light, cool, and gentle wind. 🌬️
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"There's a handle":** A tool for the passenger to use.
    - **"that you turn":** The action you take.
    - **"to make a breeze":** To let in fresh air or turn on a fan.

- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** If the room feels a bit hot or stuffy, you don't have to suffer. There is a special handle or vent that you can turn. When you turn it, cool, fresh air starts flowing into your room. It keeps you feeling fresh throughout the night trip. 🍦
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Modernity**. At the time this was written, having a "breeze" control on a train was very high-tech and fancy. 🚀

Line 39

"There's a funny little basin you're supposed to wash your face in"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Basin:** A small sink or bowl for washing. 🚿
    - **Supposed to:** What you are expected to do.
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"There's a funny little basin":** A small, cute sink.
    - **"you're supposed to wash your face in":** Designed for your morning or night-time washing.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Space on a train is small, so the sink (basin) is "funny" and tiny. It is built perfectly to fit in the corner so you can wash your face and hands before you go to sleep or when you wake up. It's like a tiny, moving bathroom just for you. 🧼 🧴
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Efficiency**. The train uses every inch of space to provide comfort. It's a "machine for living." 🧩

Line 40

"And a crank to shut the window if you sneeze."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Crank:** A handle you turn in a circle to move something (like a window). 🔄

    - **Sneeze:** When air comes out of your nose suddenly because of cold or dust. 🤧

- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"And a crank":** A mechanical handle.
    - **"to shut the window":** To close the glass.
    - **"if you sneeze":** If you start feeling cold or sick.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** If you are sitting by the window and the night air makes you feel cold (and you start sneezing), you don't have to struggle. You just use the "crank" handle to roll the window up tightly. It protects you from the weather outside. 🖼️ ❄️
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Protection**. The train (under Skimble's watch) protects you from the harsh "outside" world. 🛡️ ☁️

Line 41

"Then the guard looks in politely and will ask you very brightly"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Politely:** With good manners and respect. 🙏
    - **Brightly:** In a happy, cheerful, and energetic way. 😄
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Then the guard looks in politely":** The train worker checks on you with a smile.
    - **"and will ask you very brightly":** He speaks to you in a very friendly tone.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Just as you are getting settled, a train guard (worker) knocks on your door. He isn't rude or tired; he is very well-mannered and happy. He treats you like an important guest in a fancy hotel. He is there to take your "order" for the next morning. 👮 👋

- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Human Connection**. Even though the train is a machine, the people working on it (because of Skimble) are kind and happy. 🤝🌞

Line 42

""Do you like your morning tea weak or strong?""

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Weak:** Tea with a lot of water/milk and not much tea flavor. 🧉💧
    - **Strong:** Tea with a lot of tea leaves and a very powerful taste. 🧉🔥
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Do you like your morning tea":** Asking about your breakfast preference.
    - **"weak or strong?":** Giving you a choice of how you like it.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The guard wants to make sure you wake up happy. He asks you exactly how you like your tea so that when he brings it to you in the morning, it is perfect for your taste. It shows that the service on this train is very detailed. 🧉🥐
- **Deep Meaning:** This represents **Choice**. The train service isn't just "one size fits all." It is made for *you*. 🎯

Line 43

"But Skimble's just behind him and was ready to remind him,"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Behind him:** Following the guard.
    - **Remind him:** To tell someone something they might have forgotten. 🧠💡
- **Phrase Breakdown:**

    - **"But Skimble's just behind him":** The cat is following the guard like a supervisor.
    - **"and was ready to remind him":** Skimble is watching to make sure the guard does his job correctly.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The guard is being nice, but the reason he is being *so* perfect is that Skimble is right there! The cat is walking right behind the guard's heels. If the guard forgets to ask a passenger something or makes a mistake, Skimble is there to "remind" him with a look or a nudge. Skimble is the "manager" of the staff. 🐾👮
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Supervision**. Even the human workers need a leader. Skimble ensures the staff stays "polite" and "bright." He is the boss of the bosses. 👮😼

Line 44

"For Skimble won't let anything go wrong."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Won't let:** Will not allow. 🚫
    - **Go wrong:** To have a problem or a mistake. ❌
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"For Skimble won't let":** Because the cat will never allow it.
    - **"anything go wrong":** Any mistake to happen on his train.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** This is Skimble's life mission. He is obsessed with perfection. Whether it is a dirty floor, a rude guard, or a cold cup of tea—Skimble will stop it before it happens. He is the reason the train has a perfect record. 💯🛡️
- **Deep Meaning:** This is **Responsibility**. Skimble takes the entire weight of the train's success on his small shoulders. He is the ultimate guardian of "The Right Way." ⚖️✨

Line 45

"And when you creep into your cosy berth"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Creep:** To move slowly, quietly, and carefully. 🤫
    - **Cosy:** Feeling warm, comfortable, and safe (like being under a blanket on a rainy day). 🧸
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"And when you creep":** When you slowly climb in.
    - **"into your cosy berth":** Into your warm, comfortable train bed.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Finally, after a long day, you quietly slide into your bed. The bed feels warm and soft. The motion of the train is like a cradle rocking you to sleep. It is the most comfortable feeling in the world. 😴🛌✨
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Peace**. After the "frantic" start of the poem, we have finally reached a state of total rest. 🕊️🌙

Line 46

"And pull up the counterpane,"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Counterpane:** A fancy, decorative cover for a bed (a bedspread or thick blanket). 🛏️🛌
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"And pull up":** To lift the blanket over your body.
    - **"the counterpane":** The top bed cover.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** You pull the thick, heavy blanket up to your chin to keep out the night chill. You are now fully "tucked in" and ready for a long sleep while the train travels hundreds of miles. 🛌❄️
- **Deep Meaning:** This is a symbol of **Completion**.

Line 47

"You ought to reflect that it's very nice"

- **Tough Words:**
  - **Ought to:** Should (it is a good idea to do this).
  - **Reflect:** To think deeply or quietly about something. 🧠💭
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
  - **"You ought to reflect":** You should take a moment to think.
  - **"that it's very nice":** About how lucky and happy you are.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** As you lie there in the dark, you should take a moment to think about how lucky you are. You are warm, safe, and comfortable. You should appreciate the great service and the peace you feel. 😌💭
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Gratitude**. The poet wants the reader to appreciate the "invisible work" that goes into making life comfortable. 🙏✨

Line 48

"To know that you won't be bothered by mice—"

- **Tough Words:**
  - **Bothered:** Disturbed, annoyed, or made to feel scared. 🐭🚫
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
  - **"To know that you":** To have the confidence.
  - **"won't be bothered by mice—":** That no mice will run across your feet or eat your food.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** One of the biggest problems on old trains was mice! They would come out at night to eat crumbs. But on the Night

Mail, you don't have to worry. Not a single mouse would dare to come near your room. Why? Because there is a predator on board! 🐭🏃🕛

- **Deep Meaning:** This is the **Traditional Role** of a cat.

Line 49

"You can leave all that to the Railway Cat,"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Leave all that to:** To let someone else handle the problem so you don't have to worry. 👐✅
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"You can leave all that":** You can hand over all your worries.
    - **"to the Railway Cat":** To Skimbleshanks.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** You don't need to stay awake to guard your bags or watch for mice. You can close your eyes and sleep deeply because Skimbleshanks is awake for you. He is the one who handles the "dirty work" so you can enjoy the "luxury." 😴🐱
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Trust**.

Line 50

"The Cat of the Railway Train!"

- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"The Cat":** The one and only.
    - **"of the Railway Train!":** The master of this entire world.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The poet ends this section by giving Skimble his "Official Title." He isn't just a stray cat who walked onto a train. He is *the* official Cat of the entire railway system. He owns this place. 🚂🐈‍⬛👑
- **Deep Meaning:** This is **Identification**.

Line 51

"In the watches of the night he is always fresh and bright;"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Watches of the night:** The quiet, late-night hours when most people are asleep (usually between midnight and dawn). 🌙
    - **Fresh and bright:** Feeling energetic, awake, and ready for work (not tired). ⚡
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"In the watches of the night":** During the very late hours.
    - **"he is always fresh and bright":** He stays wide awake and full of energy.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** While all the human passengers are tucked under their blankets and snoring, Skimbleshanks is not tired at all. Even at 2 or 3 in the morning, he looks like he just woke up from a long nap. His eyes are wide, and he is ready to do his job. He doesn't get sleepy or lazy like humans do during the night; he is the perfect night-watchman. 🐈‍⬛👀
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Commitment**. A true leader doesn't stop working just because it's dark or because no one is watching. Skimble's "brightness" in the dark shows he is a symbol of light and safety. 🕯️

Line 52

"Every now and then he has a cup of tea"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Every now and then:** Occasionally; from time to time. 🕰️
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Every now and then":** Once in a while.
    - **"he has a cup of tea":** He takes a small break for a drink.

- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Even a hard-working cat needs a little break. To stay "fresh and bright," Skimble joins the human workers (like the guards or drivers) for a warm cup of tea. It's a very British way of staying awake and keeping warm during a long, cold night journey. 🍵
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Friendship**. By drinking tea "with" the workers, Skimble shows he is part of the team. He isn't just a boss who gives orders; he is a friend who shares a drink with his staff. 🤝

Line 53

"With perhaps a drop of Scotch while he's keeping on the watch,"

- **Tough Words:**
  - **Scotch:** A type of strong Scottish whiskey. 🛋️
  - **Keeping on the watch:** Staying alert and guarding the area. 👮
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
  - **"With perhaps a drop of Scotch":** Maybe adding a tiny bit of alcohol to his tea (this is a joke by the poet!).
  - **"while he's keeping on the watch":** While he is doing his guard duty.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The poet adds a funny detail here. He says that maybe Skimble adds a tiny drop of Scotch whiskey to his tea to keep him extra warm as the train moves through the freezing mountains of Scotland. Even while he is having this "grown-up" drink, he never stops being a guard. He is always looking out for the safety of the train. 😼🛋️
- **Deep Meaning:** This is **Whimsy** (Humor). T.S. Eliot is making Skimble sound like a tough, old railway worker who has been doing this job for years. It adds personality to the cat. 🎭

Line 54

"Only stopping here and there to catch a flea."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Flea:** A tiny jumping insect that lives on animals. 🪰
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Only stopping here and there":** Taking very short pauses.
    - **"to catch a flea":** To groom himself or scratch.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Even though he acts like a serious human manager, we are reminded that he is still a real cat! Every once in a while, he has to stop his serious patrolling to scratch an itch or catch a tiny flea in his fur. It's the only time he stops working, and it only takes a second before he is back on duty. 🐾
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Humility**. No matter how "important" he is (manager, boss, guardian), he is still a cat. It's a touch of reality that makes us like him even more. 😊

Line 55

"You were fast asleep at Crewe and so you never knew"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Crewe:** A famous, very large railway town and station in England. 🚆
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"You were fast asleep":** You were in a deep sleep.
    - **"at Crewe":** While the train was stopped at this specific station.
    - **"and so you never knew":** Therefore, you didn't see what happened.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The train stopped at a big station called Crewe in the middle of the night. You, the passenger, were dreaming and didn't even wake up when the train pulled into the station. Because you were sleeping so soundly in your "cosy berth," you missed seeing Skimble's hard work. 😴💤

- **Deep Meaning:** This represents **Invisible Service**. Most of the things that keep us safe in life happen while we aren't looking. Skimble works "behind the scenes" so we don't have to worry. 🛡️ ✨

Line 56

"That he was walking up and down the station;"

- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"That he was walking":** The action he was taking.
    - **"up and down the station":** Moving along the entire platform.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** While the train was stopped at the station, Skimble didn't stay inside to rest. He jumped down onto the platform and walked from one end to the other. He was likely checking the wheels, looking at the other workers, and making sure the station was safe before the train continued its journey. 🚂 🏞️
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Over-and-Above Duty**. He doesn't just guard the *inside* of the train; he guards the *outside* too. He takes responsibility for everything around him. 💪

Line 57

"You were sleeping all the while he was busy at Carlisle,"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Carlisle:** Another major railway station near the border of England and Scotland. 🏴 □□□□□□
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"You were sleeping all the while":** You slept through the whole time.
    - **"he was busy at Carlisle":** He was working hard at the next big station.

- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The night continues, and the train reaches the next big city, Carlisle. You are still asleep! But Skimble is still "busy." He is using the stop to do more inspections and talk to the people who work at that station. He never seems to get tired. 🚂🕒
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Consistency**. Whether it is the start of the trip or the middle of the night at a far-away station, Skimble's hard work never changes. 📉💎

Line 58

"Where he greets the stationmaster with elation."

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Greets:** To say hello or welcome someone. 👋
    - **Stationmaster:** The "boss" of the whole railway station.
    - **Elation:** A feeling of great happiness and excitement. 😁✨
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Where he greets":** Where he says hello.
    - **"the stationmaster":** The big boss of Carlisle station.
    - **"with elation":** With a lot of joy and energy.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** When Skimble sees the boss of Carlisle station, he doesn't just meow—he greets him with "elation." He is very happy to see his fellow railway workers. This shows that Skimble is famous all along the railway line. Every stationmaster knows him and is happy to see the famous "Railway Cat" arrive on time. 🤝🐈
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Professional Respect**. Skimble is treated as an equal by the human bosses. It shows that if you do your job well, people will respect you no matter who you are. 🏅

Line 59

"But you saw him at Dumfries, where he speaks to the police"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Dumfries:** A town in Scotland. 🏴□□□□□□
    - **Speaks to the police:** Communicates with the security/officers. 👮‍♂️
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"But you saw him at Dumfries":** You finally woke up and saw him at this station.
    - **"where he speaks to the police":** Where he is talking to the law enforcement officers.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** By the time the train gets to Dumfries, it is morning, and you are finally awake. You look out the window and see Skimble on the platform. He is "talking" to the police officers there. Of course, he is a cat, so he isn't speaking English, but he is interacting with them in a way that shows he is giving them information or checking for safety. 👮‍♂️😼
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Cooperation**. Skimble works with the "Law." He ensures that the train is safe and follows all the rules. It makes him seem like a secret agent for the railway. 🕵️‍♀️⚖️

Line 60

"If there's anything they ought to know about:"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Ought to:** Should.
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"If there's anything":** If there is any problem or news.
    - **"they ought to know about":** That the police should be informed of.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** Skimble acts as the messenger. If he saw something suspicious during the night—like a door that was left open or a

strange person on the tracks—he makes sure the police find out about it. He is the eyes and ears of the entire journey. 📢⚠️

- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Information Power**. Knowledge is important for safety. Skimble's job is to gather information and share it with the right people to keep everyone safe. 🧠📊

Line 61

"When you get to Gallowgate there you do not have to wait—"

- **Tough Words:**
    - **Gallowgate:** A location/station (likely in Glasgow, Scotland). 🏁
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"When you get to Gallowgate":** When you reach your final destination.
    - **"there you do not have to wait—":** You won't face any delays getting off the train.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The journey is ending! You have arrived at Gallowgate. Usually, getting off a train can be slow and annoying, but not on Skimble's train. Everything is organized so perfectly that the doors open immediately and you can walk right out. 🚪🏃‍♂️💨
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Efficiency to the End**. A good leader doesn't stop working until the very last person is safe and happy. He makes sure the "exit" is as perfect as the "entry." ✅

Line 62

"For Skimbleshanks will help you to get out!"

- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"For Skimbleshanks":** Because the cat.
    - **"will help you to get out!":** Will make sure you leave the train safely.

- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** As you leave the carriage, there is Skimble! He is there at the door or on the platform, almost like he is saying, "Watch your step!" He is making sure all his passengers leave the train in a happy and organized way. He has been with you from the start, and he is there at the finish. 🐈‍⬛👋
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **End-to-End Service**. Skimble takes full responsibility for your entire experience. He is a true host. 🏨✨

Line 63

"He gives you a wave of his long brown tail"

- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"He gives you a wave":** A goodbye gesture.
    - **"of his long brown tail":** Using his tail like a hand waving goodbye.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** As you walk away from the train into the city, you look back one last time. Skimble isn't meowing or crying; he just flickers his long brown tail in the air. It's his polite and cool way of saying "Goodbye" and "Have a nice day." 🐈‍⬛👋✨
- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Grace**. Even his goodbye is "nimble" and "cool." He doesn't need a big ceremony; a simple wave of the tail is enough. 🌊

Line 64

"Which says: "I'll see you again!"

- **Phrase Breakdown:**
    - **"Which says":** The meaning behind the tail wave.
    - **""I'll see you again!":** A promise for the future.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** That wave of the tail isn't just a "Bye-bye." It's a promise. Skimble is telling you that the next time you take the Midnight Mail, he will be there waiting for you. He is a permanent part of the journey. 🚂🤝

- **Deep Meaning:** This shows **Reliability**. In a world that is always changing, Skimble is someone you can count on. He will always be there. 💎

Line 65

"You'll meet without fail on the Midnight Mail"

- **Tough Words:**
  - **Without fail:** Definitely; 100% certain to happen. ✅ 💯
  - **Midnight Mail:** The name of the famous train.
- **Phrase Breakdown:**
  - **"You'll meet without fail":** You will definitely see him again.
  - **"on the Midnight Mail":** On this specific train journey.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The poet guarantees it: if you ever travel on this train again, you don't even have to ask if Skimble is there. He **will** be there. He never takes a holiday, and he never misses a trip. He is the heart and soul of the Midnight Mail. 🚂 📬
- **Deep Meaning:** This is **Permanence**. Skimble is more than just a cat; he is an institution. He is as much a part of the railway as the tracks themselves. 🏞️ ❤️‍🩹

Line 66

"The Cat of the Railway Train."

- **Phrase Breakdown:**
  - **"The Cat":** The one, the only, the legend. 🐈‍⬛
  - **"of the Railway Train.":** His official title.
- **Literal Meaning (Extended):** The poem ends by reminding us of his title. He isn't just "Skimble"; he is **THE Cat of the Railway Train**. He is the master of this world of steam, iron, and mail. 🚂 👑
- **Deep Meaning:** This is the **Final Stamp of Authority**.

Stanza 1 (Lines 1–12) 🏁

- **L1:** "There's a whisper down the line at 11.39" — **Onomatopoeia** ("whisper") 🤫
- **L2:** "When the Night Mail's ready to depart," — **Imagery** ("Night Mail") ✉️
- **L3:** "Saying 'Skimble where is Skimble has he gone to hunt the thimble?'" — **Internal Rhyme** (Skimble/thimble) 🤦‍♀️
- **L4:** "We must find him or the train can't start."" — **Personification** (The train needs the cat to move) 🚫
- **L5:** "All the guards and all the porters and the stationmaster's daughters" — **Polysyndeton** (Repeating "and") 👥
- **L6:** "They are searching high and low," — **Alliteration** ("s" in searching/station) 🔍
- **L7:** "Saying 'Skimble where is Skimble for unless he's very nimble" — **Internal Rhyme** (Skimble/nimble) 🤸
- **L8:** "Then the Night Mail just can't go."" — **Repetition** (Repeating the idea from line 4) 🛑
- **L9:** "At 11.42 then the signal's nearly due" — **Imagery** ("signal") 🚦
- **L10:** "And the passengers are frantic to a man—" — **Hyperbole** (Exaggerating everyone's panic) 😨
- **L11:** "Then Skimble will appear and he'll saunter to the rear:" — **Consonance** ("r" sound in saunter/rear) 😎
- **L12:** "He's been busy in the luggage van!" — **Alliteration** ("b" in been/busy) 📦

Stanza 2 (Lines 13–32) 🏞️

- **L13:** "He gives one flash of his glass-green eyes" — **Imagery** ("glass-green eyes") ✨
- **L14:** "And the signal goes 'All Clear!'" — **Personification** (The signal "speaks") ✅

- **L15:** "And we're off at last for the northern part" — **Alliteration** ("n" in northern) 🌬️
- **L16:** "Of the Northern Hemisphere!" — **Hyperbole** (Talking about the whole world) 🌍
- **L17:** "You may say that by and large it is Skimble who's in charge" — **Internal Rhyme** (large/charge) 👑
- **L18:** "Of the Sleeping Car Express." — **Imagery** ("Sleeping Car") 🛌
- **L19:** "From the driver and the guards to the bagmen playing cards" — **Imagery** ("playing cards") 🃏
- **L20:** "He will supervise them all, more or less." — **Personification** (Cat as a supervisor) 🧐
- **L21:** "Down the corridor he paces and examines all the faces" — **Rhyme** (paces/faces) 🐈
- **L22:** "Of the travellers in the First and the Third;" — **Contrast** (Comparing First and Third class) ⚖️
- **L23:** "He establishes control by a regular patrol" — **Alliteration** ("p" in patrol) 👮
- **L24:** "And he'd know at once if anything occurred." — **Assonance** ("o" in know/occurred) ⚠️
- **L25:** "He will watch you without winking and he sees what you are thinking" — **Alliteration** ("w" in watch/winking) 👁️
- **L26:** "And it's certain that he doesn't approve" — **Personification** (Cat having an opinion) ❌
- **L27:** "Of hilarity and riot, so the folk are very quiet" — **Rhyme** (riot/quiet) 🤫
- **L28:** "When Skimble is about and on the move." — **Idiom** ("on the move") 🚶
- **L29:** "You can play no pranks with Skimbleshanks!" — **Internal Rhyme** (pranks/shanks) 🃏

- **L30:** "He's a Cat that cannot be ignored;" — **Strong Statement** (Emphasizing his power) 🌟
- **L31:** "So nothing goes wrong on the Northern Mail" — **Alliteration** ("n" in Northern Mail) ✅
- **L32:** "When Skimbleshanks is aboard." — **Repetition** (His name) 🚂

Stanza 3 (Lines 33–50) 🛌

- **L33:** "Oh, it's very pleasant when you have found your little den" — **Metaphor** (Room is called a "den") 🏠
- **L34:** "With your name written up on the door." — **Imagery** (Name on door) 🏷️
- **L35:** "And the berth is very neat with a newly folded sheet" — **Internal Rhyme** (neat/sheet) ✨
- **L36:** "And there's not a speck of dust on the floor." — **Imagery** (No dust) 🧹
- **L37:** "There is every sort of light—you can make it dark or bright;" — **Antithesis** (Opposites: dark/bright) 💡
- **L38:** "There's a handle that you turn to make a breeze." — **Imagery** ("breeze") 🌬️
- **L39:** "There's a funny little basin you're supposed to wash your face in" — **Internal Rhyme** (basin/face in) 🚿
- **L40:** "And a crank to shut the window if you sneeze." — **Onomatopoeia** ("sneeze") 🤧
- **L41:** "Then the guard looks in politely and will ask you very brightly" — **Alliteration** ("l" in looks/politely) 🙏
- **L42:** ""Do you like your morning tea weak or strong?"" — **Contrast** (weak/strong) ☕
- **L43:** "But Skimble's just behind him and was ready to remind him," — **Personification** (Cat reminding humans) 🧠
- **L44:** "For Skimble won't let anything go wrong." — **Personification** (Cat's responsibility) 🛡️

- **L45**: "And when you creep into your cosy berth" — **Alliteration** ("c" in creep/cosy) 🛌
- **L46**: "And pull up the counterpane," — **Imagery** ("counterpane") 🛏️
- **L47**: "You ought to reflect that it's very nice" — **Assonance** ("e" in reflect/very) 💭
- **L48**: "To know that you won't be bothered by mice—" — **Imagery** ("mice") 🐭
- **L49**: "You can leave all that to the Railway Cat," — **Epithet** ("Railway Cat") 🛡️
- **L50**: "The Cat of the Railway Train!" — **Repetition** (Title) 🚂

Stanza 4 (Lines 51–66) 🌙

- **L51**: "In the watches of the night he is always fresh and bright;" — **Alliteration** ("w" in watches) 🌙
- **L52**: "Every now and then he has a cup of tea" — **Imagery** ("cup of tea") 🍵
- **L53**: "With perhaps a drop of Scotch while he's keeping on the watch," — **Rhyme** (Scotch/watch) 🛋️
- **L54**: "Only stopping here and there to catch a flea." — **Imagery** ("flea") 🐜
- **L55**: "You were fast asleep at Crewe and so you never knew" — **Internal Rhyme** (Crewe/knew) 😴
- **L56**: "That he was walking up and down the station;" — **Alliteration** ("w" in walking) 🚶
- **L57**: "You were sleeping all the while he was busy at Carlisle," — **Internal Rhyme** (while/Carlisle) 💤
- **L58**: "Where he greets the stationmaster with elation." — **Alliteration** ("s" in stationmaster) 😁
- **L59**: "But you saw him at Dumfries, where he speaks to the police" — **Internal Rhyme** (Dumfries/police) 👮

- **L60:** "If there's anything they ought to know about:" — **Assonance** ("o" in know/about) 📢
- **L61:** "When you get to Gallowgate there you do not have to wait—" — **Internal Rhyme** (Gallowgate/wait) 🏁
- **L62:** "For Skimbleshanks will help you to get out!" — **Personification** (Helping out) 🐈‍⬛
- **L63:** "He gives you a wave of his long brown tail" — **Imagery** (Tail wave) 👋
- **L64:** "Which says: "I'll see you again!" — **Personification** (Tail "speaking") 💬
- **L65:** "You'll meet without fail on the Midnight Mail" — **Internal Rhyme** (fail/Mail) 🤝
- **L66:** "The Cat of the Railway Train."" — **Refrain** (Final repeating title) 👑